

Stenopterygius

Long before dolphins first appeared, the seas of the Jurassic were home to reptiles that had evolved a remarkably similar body shape and lifestyle. These were the ichthyosaurs. One type of ichthyosaur, *Stenopterygius*, spent its life in the open ocean, where it hunted fish, cephalopods, and other marine animals.

Dorsal fin

In most large fossils only bones are visible, but in this remarkable *Stenopterygius* fossil, the fins, tail, and other soft tissues can be seen.

Backbone bends downward to support the tail.

Short hind limb

Stenopterygius

sten-OP-terr-idge-ee-us

- **When** Early to mid Jurassic
- **Fossil location** Argentina, UK, France, Germany
- **Habitat** Shallow oceans
- **Size** 13 ft (4 m) long

Like its close relative *Ichthyosaurus*, *Stenopterygius* was a dolphinlike reptile adapted to catching fish in its tooth-filled snout. Its streamlined shape and muscular fins suggest it could achieve a top speed of perhaps 60 mph (100 kph), enabling it to blast into shoals of fish like a torpedo and snatch prey in the resulting confusion.

